

Black-tailed prairie dog

Cynomys ludovicianus

A large species of ground squirrel, black-tailed prairie dogs are highly social rodents. They live in “towns”—extensive networks of underground tunnels and chambers. A town houses hundreds of dogs, all organized into smaller groups called coterie. A coterie, made up of a dozen adults and their offspring, works together to maintain their

patch of the tunnel and defend it from intruders. Coterie members share a scent, which marks them out from other groups.

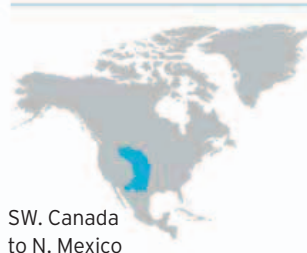
Prairie dogs dig their tunnels deep enough to avoid winter frosts. Any loose earth pushed to the surface forms mounds around the tunnel entrances that are ideal for spotting predators.



▷ FAMILY UNIT

Pups emerge from under the ground at the age of six weeks and are looked after by every member of the coterie. Most males leave the group after their first winter.

- ↔ 14–17 in (36–43 cm)
- ⚖ 2–3 lb (0.9–1.4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Grass, sedge
- 🏠 



SW. Canada
to N. Mexico

Black-footed ferret

Mustela nigripes

This solitary, burrowing hunter is one of North America’s rarest mammals. Numbers fell to 18 in the mid-1980s, but are now increasing again. About 90 percent of the black-footed ferret’s diet is made up of prairie dogs. The ferrets dig their dens right in the middle of prairie dog communities, even setting up home in unused sections of their tunnel network. They can follow prairie dogs into their burrows, killing and eating them underground.

▽ DISTINCTIVE MASK

Male and female ferrets have a well-defined mask around the eyes from an early age.



- ↔ 16–20 in (41–51 cm)
- ⚖ 2–3 lb (0.9–1.4 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🌿 Prairie dogs, mice, squirrels
- 🏠 



Reintroduced to C. US

